

PIB



KODA WITH
MANMOHAN
SINGH AND
SUBODH KANT
SAHAY IN
BETTER TIMES

If Koda's party wins a few seats, he may be kingmaker, if not king himself.

running out of options.

The sudden shift in Koda's recent behavioural pattern suggests that he has kept his nerve and could even be hoping to scrape through. He got himself admitted into a private hospital allegedly to evade questioning by IT officials and then turned defiant while refusing to visit Delhi for questioning. If the sleuths hope that the trauma of raid and interrogation coupled with public opprobrium will lead to Koda cracking up and spill the beans, they are into wishful thinking.

After all, the man has made his bones sweating it out in iron ore mines. Son of the poverty-stricken Rasika Koda, he had to start earning early as a labourer. After a stint with the All Jharkhand Students Union, Koda won the Jagannathpur Assembly seat on a BJP ticket in 2000. When the BJP denied him a ticket in 2005, Koda wept before party lead-

ers. He contested as an independent, and won. Arjun Munda—at whose behest Koda was denied a ticket—had to placate him to join his Cabinet with the mines portfolio. There he found his real calling. When Koda usurped power from Munda in 2006, he retained the Ministry of Mines.

Beyond the legal issues, the timing of the crackdown appears to be of crucial significance. Beginning November 25, the state will have five-phased Assembly polls. The results will be announced on December 23. An elected government in the state would probably take shape after Christmas. "It's a political vendetta hatched by the Congress to belittle my political stature. They want to finish me off politically, but I will not oblige them," he said while addressing a rally in Chaibasa. The Congress is putting pressure on the crackdown in the hope that it will shrink Koda's

vote-base, which they hope to grab. Koda has already floated a political outfit called Jharkhand Navnirman Morcha. He has fielded five candidates, including his wife Geeta Koda.

Seen through a political prism, the developments appear to be complementing the Congress's keenness to distance itself from Koda, whose government they had supported for 23 months. Then, Koda's money-grubbing ways didn't raise any outrage among politicians, as they were swayed by the generosity with which he shared the spoils. All the frontline political parties, including the Congress, the BJP, RJD and JMM—who have disowned Koda today when the chips are down—were once happily playing footsie with him. After all, Madhu Koda's "inclusive" political style that kept tongues sealed while he allegedly made money and let others wet their beaks suited all. ■